SOP-031: Geo Store Suggestion for Regional Shopify Stores

Author: Nícolas Cartín Reyes, Lead Developer **Date:** October 29, 2026 **Scope:** Echelon US theme first; CA, UK, DE and FR stores after the US release **Status:** Approved technical reference; US release pending approval

Purpose

This SOP replaces IP-based auto-redirects with a store suggestion. Visitors from another country see a short dialog offering their regional store. They choose; the site never moves them on its own.

Why not auto-redirect

- Third-party IP lookups add a request on every page, rate-limit, and send the visitor's IP to another company.
- Redirects also move search engine crawlers, which can stop regional pages from being indexed.
- Same-path redirects land on 404s when product handles differ between stores.
- Google and Shopify both recommend suggesting a store instead of forcing one.

How it works

- Country comes from Shopify's own `/browsing_context_suggestions.json`. No third-party API.
- A country-to-store map in `snippets/geo-store-suggest.liquid` decides which store to suggest. Unmapped countries see nothing.
- The dialog is centered, shows the country flag (inline SVG), and has two actions: "Go to [store]" and "Stay on [current store]".
- "Go" opens the same product, collection or page on the target store when it exists there (checked against Shopify's public `.js` / `.json` endpoints); otherwise it opens the home page.
- The dialog waits until the cookie banner is closed and pauses other promo popups while it is open.
- The choice is stored for 14 days only if preferences or functional consent is given (OneTrust group `C0003` or the Shopify Customer Privacy API). Without consent it lasts for the session only.
- It never runs for crawlers, in the theme editor, or on checkout and admin URLs.
- `snippets/footer-region-links.liquid` adds region links in the footer so any visitor can switch stores manually.

Accessibility

- `role="dialog"`, `aria-modal`, labelled heading, focus moves into the dialog and is trapped, Escape closes it, focus returns afterwards.
- Buttons meet WCAG 2.2 AA contrast and target size. Run axe-core on the open dialog before release.

Installing on a store

1. Duplicate the live theme as an unpublished dev copy.
2. Add both snippets. In `layout/theme.liquid`, remove the old IP redirect script and add `{%- render 'geo-store-suggest' -%}` before `</body>`.
3. Render `footer-region-links` in the footer section.
4. Update the country map and store URLs for this store, and remove the current store from the suggestions.
5. Test with `?geo_test=CA&geo_reset=1` (replace the country code), on desktop and mobile, with cookies accepted and declined.
6. Follow the controlled release steps: pull live, confirm unchanged, back up, push only the changed files, pull back and verify.

QA checklist

- Each mapped country shows the right flag and store; the current store's country and unmapped countries show nothing.
- Deep link opens the same product, collection or page, or the home page if it doesn't exist.
- Choice remembered for 14 days with consent; session only without.
- Dialog appears after the cookie banner, not on top of it.
- axe-core shows 0 violations with the dialog open.

Reference

Open-source starter: shopify-geo-store-suggestion.